

Raindrops

Every cloud holds millions of water droplets and ice crystals. They are so tiny that they are held up by air alone. Some big clouds have water droplets at the bottom and ice crystals at the top. Before rain falls, the droplets grow much bigger. Some grow by bumping into one another and joining together. Others grow by condensation.



See how they grow

In clouds forming high in the sky, water vapor freezes onto ice crystals, and they grow into snowflakes. Then they fall from the cloud. As they fall through warmer air, they melt into raindrops.

Tiny water droplets bump into each other and cling together as they fall.

Drop by drop

As a raindrop falls, it gathers up smaller ones below, growing all the time. The biggest raindrops are about $\frac{1}{8}$ in (5 mm) across. But drizzle measures less than 0.02 in (0.5 mm) across.

Raindrops send up a splash of water. However, drizzle does not make splashes on water.

